



Three Studies, One Spiral

How Gerlach, Cha and Dane each worked
Creswell and Poth's five analysis activities

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THE CLAIM OF THIS DECK

All three papers are arguments against knowing the answer before you collect the data. They make that argument three different ways, and the differences are where the method lives.

Read in full, 18 September. Every figure that follows is built from numbers reported in the papers.



THE THREE PAPERS

What each one was trying to do

Gerlach & Cenfetelli (2020)

MIS Quarterly · Grounded theory, Glaser

The field's category was BORROWED. Addiction was applied, in their words, in a confirmatory manner

Cha & Edmondson (2006)

Leadership Quarterly · Longitudinal single case

Their OWN category was wrong. They went in to study the positive effects of strong values

Dane (2020)

Acad. Mgmt Discoveries · Modified GT, Corbin & Strauss + Gioia

NO category existed. Nobody had a vocabulary for how people make sense of an epiphany

ALL THREE ARE INDUCTIVE. NONE STARTED FROM A HYPOTHESIS.

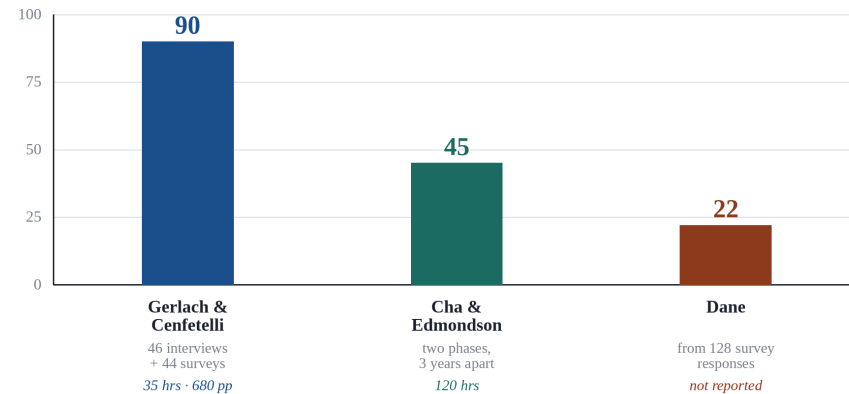


DESIGN SHAPE

Sample size is not the same thing as evidence

Three ways to build an evidence base

Participants interviewed or surveyed, with fieldwork hours where the paper reports them



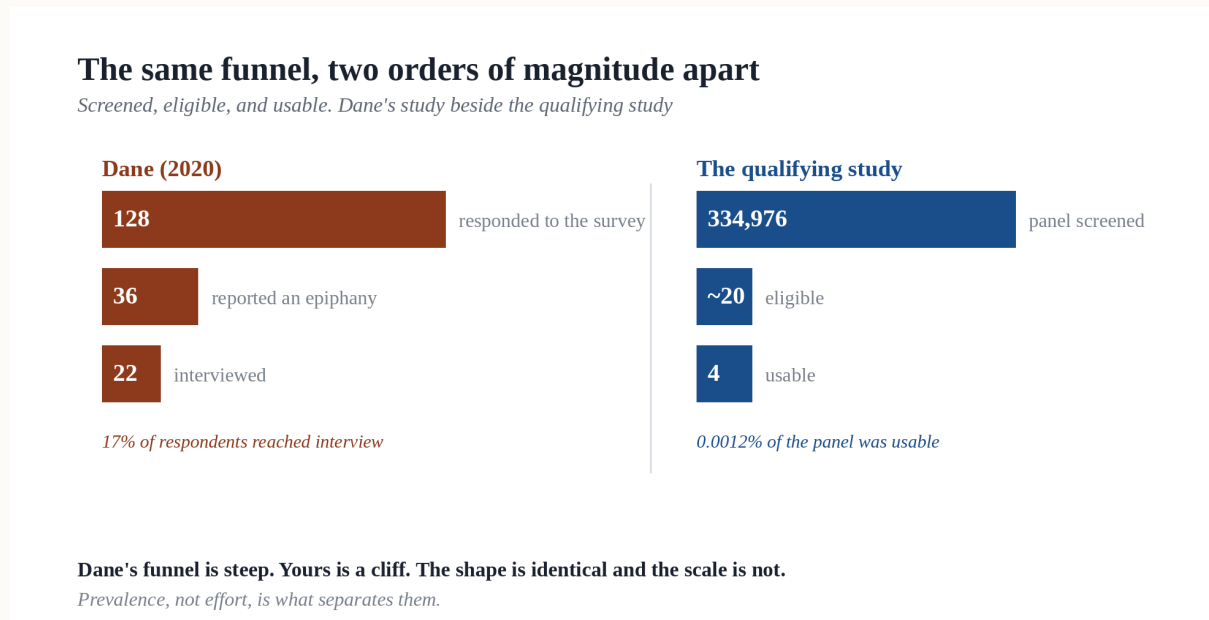
*Cha and Edmondson interviewed the fewest people and spent the most hours with them.
Sample size and evidence are not the same quantity.*

Gerlach reached the most people. Cha and Edmondson reached the fewest and learned the most from them, because they went back three years later. Dane reports no hours at all, which is itself worth noticing.



PREVALENCE

The same funnel, two orders of magnitude apart

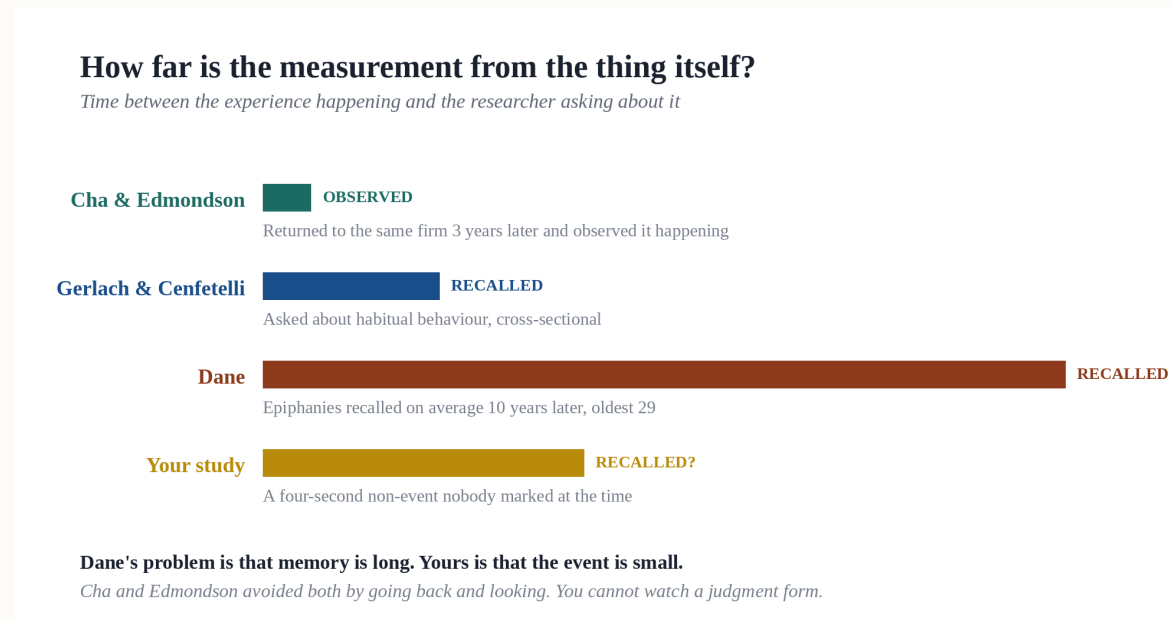


Dane screened 128 people to interview 22. My qualifying study screened 334,976 to keep four. The shape is identical. What differs is prevalence, and prevalence is not something effort can fix.



EVIDENTIARY STRATEGY

How far the measurement sits from the thing itself



This is the question my own design has to answer. Dane's participants recall an epiphany from up to twenty-nine years ago, and epiphanies are vivid. Mine would recall four seconds nobody marked at the time.



RING 3 · DESCRIBING AND CLASSIFYING

Three ladders, all called inductive

GERLACH

Glaser (1978)

Open coding

line by line, phrase level



Selective coding

one construct earns the centre



Theoretical coding

relationships, validated

CHA & EDMONDSON

Emic, inductive

Observation

across two phases



Interview

36 in phase 2 alone



Archival

the record around it

DANE

Gioia et al. (2013)

First-order data

participants' own terms



Theoretical categories

named by the analyst



Aggregate dimensions

four of them

Constant comparison is the engine under the first. A three-year gap is the engine under the second. Iterating between collection and analysis is the engine under the third.



RING 4 · DEVELOPING AND ASSESSING INTERPRETATIONS

Where the three actually separate

Every paper describes how it built an interpretation. Only some describe how they tried to break one.

GERLACH

Designed disconfirmation IN, before fielding

Ran anonymous surveys specifically to test for interview bias, and an MTurk sample specifically to test the convenience sample. Both reported no difference.

...and no threshold was stated for what a difference would have been. A check that can only return the expected answer is weaker than it looks.

CHA & EDMONDSON

Had their interpretation overturned, and followed it

Went in to document the positive effects of strong values. Developed theory about negative outcomes, in their words, after we observed them.

The strongest instance of assessment in the three, and it was not a procedure. It was a willingness to lose the original question.

DANE

Worked alone

Single author, first person throughout: I read each interview transcript multiple times. Four aggregate dimensions identified.

No inter-coder statistic, and no external check reported. Defensible, and it should be argued rather than left silent.

NOBODY REPORTS INTER-CODER AGREEMENT. THREE DIFFERENT DEFENCES, ALL UNSTATED.



WHAT THIS CHANGES FOR MY PROPOSAL

Four things I take from reading all three

1

Ring 4 is where my protocol is thinnest

Member checking and an audit trail are Gerlach's family of answer. I should say so, rather than leaving them as generic trustworthiness language.

2

Ring 5 is a real gap

All three papers end in a figure. Phenomenology ends in prose. I have not decided what a reader actually sees.

3

My phenomenon is a non-event

Dane's problem is that memory is long. Mine is that the event is small. The grounding move is my eligibility screen, not a courtesy.

4

Ethics is the spine, and mine is severed

IRB-25-0462 covers an anonymous survey. My arm is audio-recorded interviews with identifiable participants, and it is not submitted.



THE THROUGH LINE

All three refused to know the answer first. They refused it in three different ways.

Gerlach refused a category the field had already assigned. Cha and Edmondson had theirs overturned by what they saw and followed it rather than defending it. Dane had no category at all and built one.

The five analysis activities are not a checklist. They are the machinery that makes refusing to know the answer first survive contact with a deadline.

WHY THIS IS MY TOPIC TOO

Gerlach's charge is that the addiction literature applied its construct in a confirmatory manner. My study asks what happens when an auditor agrees with a conclusion that arrived already formed.

SAME FAILURE. DIFFERENT SETTING.